the community are so distributed as best to subserve the common good'. And Article 39 (c) expected the state to ensure 'that the operation of economic system does not result in the concentration of wealth and means of production to the common detriment'.

Land was a provincial subject in the 1935 Government of India Act. It was continued as a state subject in the Constitution. The placement of land in the State List and lack of assignment of any specific role to the Central government with respect to land reforms in the Constitution resulted in the Centre not having any formal leadership role in matters concerning land reforms.

It Took Twenty-Five Years to Build Consensus on Land Ceiling Reforms

A Congress Agrarian Reforms Committee was appointed in 1947 with J.C. Kumarappa as chairman. It made clear recommendations on removal of intermediaries and conferring tenurial rights, but not explicitly on land ceilings.

The Planning Commission appointed a Panel on Land Reforms under the chairmanship of Gulzarilal Nanda in May 1955. It recommended that the family be taken as the real operative unit in land ownership; for this purpose, the aggregate area held by all members of a family should be taken into account. The panel defined family widely to consist of husband, wife, dependent sons and daughters and grandchildren, and exclude land held by married daughters and earning sons.

This Commission was, however, quite generous in recommending exclusion of several categories of landholders from the ceiling: sugarcane farms owned by sugar factories, orchards, plantations, special farms such as cattle breeding and dairy farms, farms in a compact block, efficient, mechanized farms and farms with heavy investment. The appropriate basic